

NORTHWESTERN AFRICA

MOROCCO, ALGERIA, TUNISIA, LIBYA, and Western Sahara make up the northwestern corner of Africa. Most of the region's peoples are Arabic-speaking Muslims whose ancestors came to the area from the Middle East. From the 1530s to the 1830s, the region was part of the Turkish Ottoman Empire. It was then ruled by the colonial powers of France, Italy, and Spain, until the various countries gained independence in the mid-1900s. These countries are described as "middle income," thanks largely to their rich supplies of oil and gas.

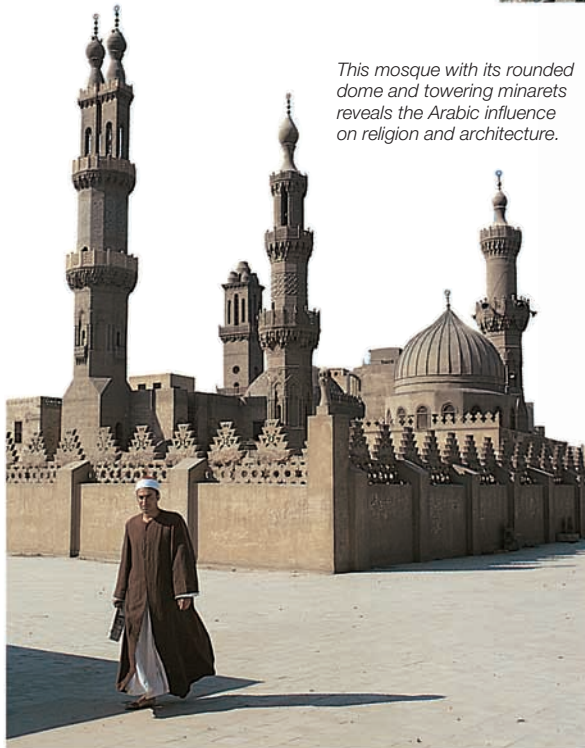
A GROWING POPULATION

One of the most serious problems facing northwestern Africa is the rapid growth of its population. In Algeria alone, the population increased 31 million between 1966 and 2000. Millions of people have moved from the countryside to the cities in search of work. This has led to severe housing shortages in the city centers and to the rise of overcrowded shantytowns on the outskirts.



ALONG THE COAST

The vast majority of northwestern Africa's 75 million people live along the narrow coastal plain that borders the Mediterranean Sea and the Atlantic Ocean. Here, the climate is warm and wet in winter and hot and dry in summer, making it more suitable for farming than the arid desert farther inland. Citrus fruits, dates, olives, tomatoes, and flowers are grown. The major towns and cities are located here, too.



This mosque with its rounded dome and towering minarets reveals the Arabic influence on religion and architecture.

ARAB INFLUENCE

The Arab invasions of the 7th and 8th centuries have had a long-lasting effect on northwestern Africa. The Arabs soon outnumbered the local Berber people who rebelled against their rule. They quickly established their own language, Arabic, and their own religion, Islam, throughout the region. Despite the later arrival of European colonists, northwestern Africa today, in its language, culture, religion, and architecture, remains firmly part of the Arab world.

